

connect – Africa has the lowest Internet penetration rate of all the continents with just 35.2% of people online. Both Europe and South America are neck-and-neck when it comes to third spot, with both having roughly 120 million people each still to connect. Of course Europe has a population of about 830 million, while South America has a population of about 430 million, so obviously Internet penetration percentage in Europe is a lot more in comparison.

Note: These numbers are usually educated guesses and extrapolations; conflicting numbers are often found on

million users above the age of 65, and perhaps we're being ageist here, but let's assume that they're not targets for 'The Next Billion'

that companies are pandering to. That's a rough total of 300 million users who we don't expect to be online right this minute, which still leaves a massive 500 million people who really should be online right now. They're the right age, and most certainly would benefit from using the internet, if only they had access. Thus, if we're talking about 'The Next Billion' we should assume that more than half of that next billion are in India alone. Thus, this cover story...

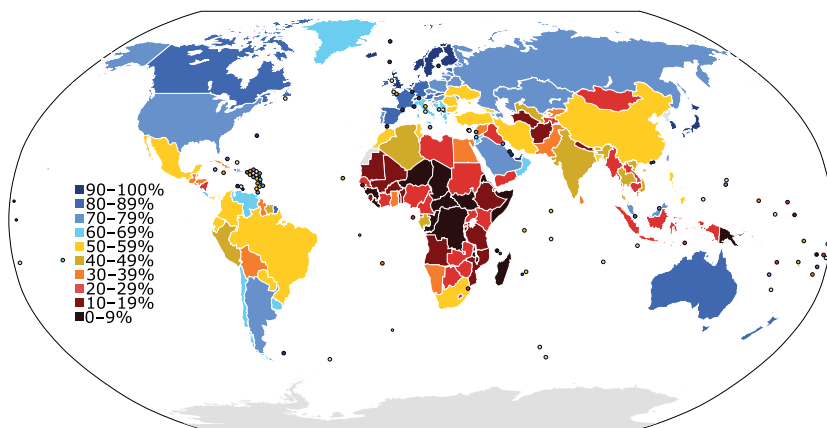
million, plus the burgeoning middle-class of India that's drawing companies to us like flies. All of us are potential customers, and because of India's vast population size, demographics and wealth distribution, there is a bigger market than most places for everything from super luxury brands to the cheapest Chinese made knick-knacks. China being all but closed off to Western companies means that we get a lot more attention than them – which raises the question of whether the attention is good or bad... we'll let you decide that for yourself.

If we look at elsewhere in the world, then China is obviously in second place for most number of non-net users (600 million as compared to our 800 million). Because it's a walled garden, however, it's safe to say that neither Western companies nor Indian startups are going to play any part or benefit from getting their 600 million online.

Our neighbour Pakistan comes in third, with about 160 million users still to be connected, however, we all know the problems faced by companies there. Indonesia is next, followed by Ethiopia, Nigeria, Congo, Bangladesh, Brazil, Myanmar, Egypt, Mexico, Tanzania, Thailand, Turkey, Philippines, Russia, Vietnam, Afghanistan, South Africa and Nepal. The reason we made that rather long list is

because after India and China, who account for over 1.3 billion non-users, and leaving aside Pakistan, we end up with all those countries together totalling the next, next billion. The entire rest of the world's non-users don't even total up to the next, next, next billion. The reason we're throwing all these numbers at you is because it's important to know where large companies are going to be focussing, and as a result, where the innovation of small startups who solve local problems will earn them funding. The future looks bright for investment in India.

Estimates by the World Resources Institute (wri.org) put the purchasing power of the next 4 billion, or as they put it, the Bottom of the Pyramid



Internet penetration by colour; data from 2016; source Wikipedia

different sites, so do not consider these numbers as precise, and instead think of them as merely representational.

Things get more interesting if you section by country. When you sort countries by sheer numbers of non-Internet users (as opposed to percentages of populations), you find that India is #1. Depending on which numbers you believe, India has between 570 and 620 million internet users. From a population of about 1.37 billion, that means we have anywhere between 750 to 800 million users still to connect to the internet. Let's assume that people above the age of 65 and children below the age of 10 (currently) cannot be counted in this total. India has about 240 million children under the age of 10 (future users in the next decade for sure, but not currently). We also have about 65

NEW MARKETS?

As much as companies want to sell you their altruistic motives, we all know that the 500+ million Indians who can get online immediately are also a huge cash cow for any company who can monopolise their attention. There's a reason Facebook wanted to give them all (and everyone else as well) free access to the Internet using their controversial "Free Basics" plan. We're still divided in Team Digit about whether it was an acceptable loss to allow a company to mess with net neutrality

in order to get those 500 million online already, or not – and we're not going down that rabbit hole again. However, we can all agree that Internet access is more a necessity than a luxury now, and not having access does hurt one's chances of bettering one's life. Needless to say, it's those 500